



alive in the minds of the living, so that he wouldn't be forgotten.

At this time, some 350 years before the Colosseum was built, there were no arenas to fight in. Instead, the men who performed at this small show fought in the city's cattle market. No one who witnessed their contest could possibly have guessed that it marked the start of Rome's liking for blood sports.

Spilling the blood

The idea of a fight at a funeral seems strange to our way of thinking. But it wasn't like this for the Romans. The Etruscans before them may have staged fights at funerals, in which a person was sacrificed. Perhaps the Romans liked the idea so much that they copied it. The main purpose of gladiatorial

A TOMB CARVING OF GLADIATORS FROM ABOUT 30 BCE. IT MAY BE A SCENE FROM THE DEAD PERSON'S FUNERAL GAMES.

games at funerals was to spill blood—it was a “gift” from the living to the dead. In their wills, wealthy or important Romans often asked for funeral games (*munera*) to be held in their honor. In staging the games, families paid respect to their dead relatives. Because funeral games were expensive, few

WEIRD WORLD

TO INSPIRE THEIR “STUDENTS,” GLADIATOR TRAINERS TOLD STORIES OF BRAVE WARRIORS WHO HAD FOUGHT WELL; SURVIVED; AND ENDED UP OWNING GRAND HOUSES, SLAVES, AND EVEN THEIR OWN GLADIATORS.